

21 UP↑ I RAJ CHENGAPPA

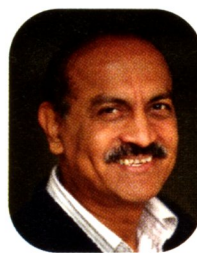
Business as Radical

Extraordinary threats require extraordinary efforts to thwart them. During World War II, in the face of dire peril from the Axis powers, the Allied Forces put together their best scientific brains and developed the world's most destructive weapon, the atom bomb, as part of the Manhattan Project. Today, global warming poses the gravest challenge to human existence ever. The climax of the negotiations among world powers to save the earth was to be the World Climate Change Conference in Copenhagen in December. Yet, with just months away, key negotiators are talking of Copenhagen being "the beginning" of a process rather than its culmination. So expectations are already being scaled down.

Yet Copenhagen represents in many ways our last chance to save ourselves and the planet. If the world fails to reach an agreement to move to a post-carbon society, the planet could turn into a living hell. What is required is business as radical, a concerted action that would capture the world's imagination and bring in a sense of urgency required to meet the enormous challenge. Apart from getting developed countries to fulfil their obligations to reduce their carbon emission levels, the world should pool its best scientific talent from any country that it is available in and work on a time-bound project to develop the most successful energy saving and carbon emission cutting source. In short, the most constructive energy saving device or devices that the humans have ever built. Make it the signature effort of the conference by calling it the Copenhagen Project, signalling the greatest and most exciting scientific cooperative endeavour to save planet earth.

One of its tasks could be developing a solar energy pack that would power not just light bulbs but also fans and television sets. Millions of villagers not just in India but also the rest of the world live in perpetual darkness or depend on candlelight or kerosene lamps that are carbon emitting. What prevents them from switching entirely to using solar packs

is that currently the storage capacity for solar batteries are low, they are expensive, difficult to maintain and are not durable. Also, luminosity is a problem and what would help is the latest LED (light-emitting diodes) technology for bulbs. Imagine if we get the world's best scientists to work on all these aspects and come out with a cheap solar pack that could revolutionise rural energy needs. That would work to not only bring light to their lives but reduce world carbon emission levels which would have otherwise risen once they started using energy from non-renewable sources. It could be the game-changer and as the technology develops it would become fashionable for the well-heeled to go solar, bringing in the big bucks to make the revolution work and support continuous innovation. At Copenhagen, this must be one of the giant steps that world leaders must take for humankind—on earth.



**AT COPENHAGEN
WHAT THE WORLD
NEEDS IS A GLOBAL
SCIENTIFIC PACT
ON THE LINES OF
THE MANHATTAN
PROJECT TO
BUILD THE MOST
ENERGY EFFICIENT
DEVICES TO SAVE
THE EARTH.**

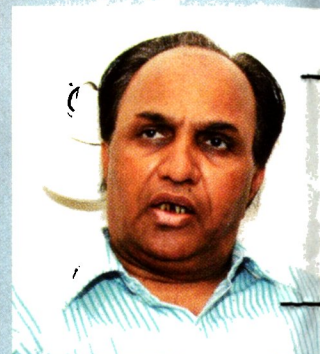


SAURABH SINGH/www.indiatodayimage.com

SIGNPOSTS

WON: By the Indian tennis team, the Davis Cup in Johannesburg, beating South Africa 4-1. This win takes India back to the elite World Group after a gap of 11 years.

DIED: Rajasthan Home Secretary **S.N. Thanvi**. He was appointed the home secretary in



June 2008 following the Gurjar agitation during which he was the principal negotiator. He was 56.

NOMINATED: Marathi film *Harishchandra Factory* by Pareshe Mokashi as India's official entry to the Oscar Awards in the foreign film category

LAUNCHED: The 6,800-tonne *INS Kochi*, India's second indigenous stealth destroyer. This is the first time any stealth destroyer has been fitted with more than 50 per cent of its equipment before its launch.

WON: By **Laxmirani Majhi**, the gold medal at the Asian Grand Prix Archery tournament at Tehran, Iran. **Rinail Buriuly** won the silver while **Dola Banerjee** bagged the bronze.